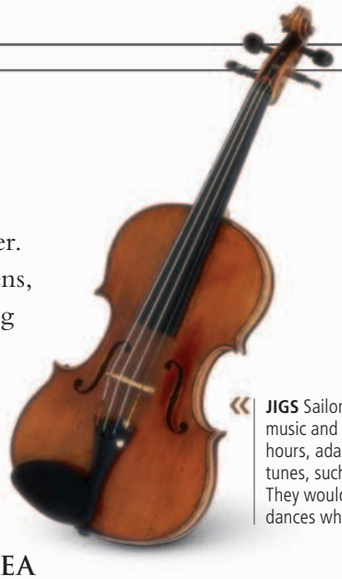
REST AND RECREATION

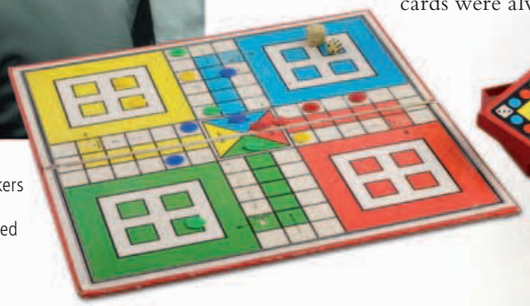
OFF-DUTY SAILORS have often had a deserved reputation for excess and disorder. Naval towns were known for their drinking establishments, brothels, gambling dens, and tattoo parlors, where seamen could be relieved of their hard-earned pay during a brief spell of shore leave, ending back on board with empty pockets and a severe hangover. But sailors, of course, have not all been drinkers and brawlers in their leisure time. They might be as likely to spend their free hours making music, sketching caricatures, or even writing poetry.



JIGS Sailors would often play music and jigs in their off-duty hours, adapting many popular tunes, such as the hornpipe. They would also play in naval dances when on shore.



PLAYING MAH JONG The Chinese game of Mah Jong was popular with sailors who were responsible for its introduction to Britain.



UCKERS BOARD A more complex form of Ludo, Uckers has a long tradition in the Royal Navy and is still played widely below decks today.

LEISURE AT SEA

At sea in the age of sail, the forecastle was the place where sailors relaxed in their off-duty hours during the week, and on Sundays after a religious service and the reading of the Articles of War. Sailors sprawled on the deck in fine weather, combing and plaiting one another's hair. They also danced and sang songs—known as fo'c'sle songs. These were distinct from sea chanties that were sung to relieve the tedium and keep rhythm while working. Younger sailors might indulge in skylarking, playing and chasing in the rigging high above the deck, a dangerous sport generally disapproved of. In a calm, the captain might have a sail let down over the side to make a swimming pool. Gambling games with dice and cards were always popular, although they were usually officially banned as counter to religious principle and a potential source of disorder—many fights on board were caused by gambling disputes.



DRUNKENNESS

Drinking alcohol to excess was always a favorite off-duty activity for sailors. While navies of the sailing-ship era issued men with alcohol as part of their daily rations, they clamped down with a heavy hand on men who drank any more than their ration on board—drunkenness was a major cause of accidents and was incompatible with the good running of a ship. Official disapproval and severe punishments did not prevent men going to extreme lengths to procure drunkenness, either illegally saving up their ration for a binge or smuggling drink on board. The ban on excessive drinking never applied to officers, who were often the most flagrant offenders, indulging in spectacular drinking bouts involving the consumption of extraordinary quantities of wine and brandy.



HORN OF PLENTY Alcohol has often fueled sailors' lives both on board and off. Beer, wine, and rum have been served by many navies as part of regular rations, although the authorities at the same time have attempted to suppress outright drunkenness.



RELAXING ON DECK Off-duty German sailors in the late 1800s are permitted some time off on a Sunday afternoon to take advantage of the fine weather and take in the fresh air before disappearing back below deck to their service.